



OFF-SIDE

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A GENUINE LOVE LOST IN DYSTOPIAN OPPORTUNISM

India didn't merely lose face in front of Lionel Messi. It revealed, yet again, **how we treat** sporting greatness. We see them as a prop for proximity, a backdrop for selfies, a means to manufacture relevance.

The last time Lionel Messi came to India, I was a rookie reporter with *Sportstar* and *The Hindu*. I remember the negotiation as much as the assignment. After days of pestering, Nirmal Shekar — the legendary tennis writer and then Sports Editor of *The Hindu* — finally allowed me to travel to Kolkata, even though two senior correspondents were already stationed there. It felt like a gift and an indulgence.

Kolkata, eternally in love with football, had slipped into carnival mode. The city had just emerged from elections, a new government replacing 34 years of Left rule, and optimism — political and sporting — hung in the air.

Argentina stayed next door to the Yuva Bharati Krirangan, and there was as much chatter about Sergio Aguero and Gonzalo Higuaín as there was about the then two-time Ballon d'Or winner. It was Messi's first game as Argentina captain.

On match day, the Salt Lake Stadium — seasoned by decades of Mohun Bagan-East Bengal hostility — had swelled to its full capacity long before kick-off. Even journalists walked nearly a kilometre before climbing five flights of stairs to the ageing press box. The two rickety lifts had surrendered long ago. Argentina won 1-0 in a game that never truly caught fire, but that hardly mattered. We had seen Messi. In person. In India.

Then came the press conference. Messi.

Alejandro Sabella. And darkness. The Yuva Bharati power supply failed at precisely the wrong moment. There were minutes of awkward silence — embarrassed journalists and helpless organisers. When electricity returned, Messi endured a string of inane questions about the city and its fans. It soon became apparent that many in the room weren't journalists at all but "well-connected fans" who had elbowed their way in.

I wrote in *Sportstar* that the "Messi match" should be a beginning. That the AIFF, then flush with proposals for more friendlies, must "build on the success, cash in on the renewed public interest and give the correct impetus to the game." But even then, I had cautioned: "Given the AIFF's track record, we shouldn't peg our hopes too high."

Fourteen years later, Indian football stares at a year without a senior national football league. **The country's most decorated footballer, Sunil Chhetri, has just played 279 minutes of football this season and was almost reduced to a prop during the Messi showcase in Mumbai.**

Much has changed in Bengal since 2011, and some of it genuinely for the better. Sport, however, remains stubbornly stagnant. Three terms of the current government have yielded little in sporting performance. Only five Bengal athletes have qualified for the last two Olympics. The State finished 18th and then eighth in the last two National Games.